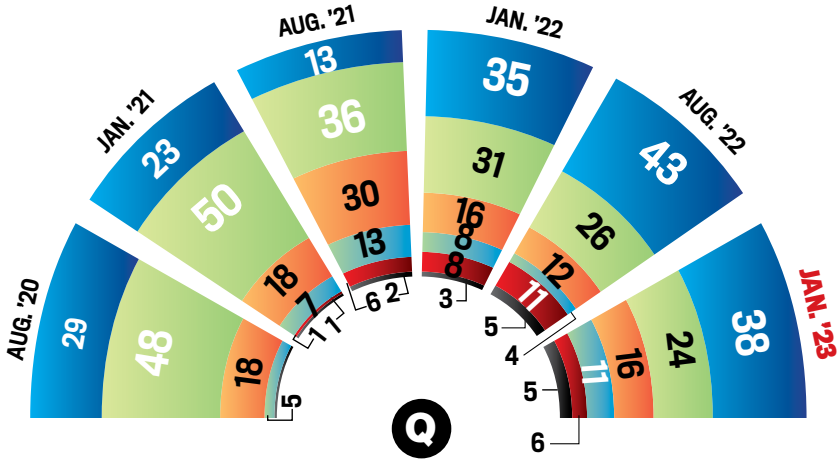
On January 23, 2023, India logged just 92 fresh Covid-19 infections and no deaths. Only 1,934 people had Covid on that date in the entire country. China, on the other hand, which is grappling with a major Covid wave triggered by Omicron sub-variant BF.7 and lifting of restrictions, saw record hospitalisations—the highest since the onset of the pandemic, per World Health Organization reports. Since August 2022, a whole bouquet of Omicron sub-variants—BA.2.12.1, BA.2.75.2, BA.3, BA.4, BA.4.6, BA.5, BQ.1, BQ.1.1, XBB and XBB 1.5—have caused surges in Covid cases the world over. But India seems to have largely escaped, not because the sub-variants did not come to India but because our extensive vaccination programme has fully immunised over 95 per cent of eligible adults besides the strong natural immunity gained from previous infections. "We have been cautious with every new sub-variant that has emerged globally. Caution and dual immunity have helped prevent new waves," says Dr N.K. Arora, chairman of the Covid working group of NTAGI.

Given the noticeable absence of spikes in Covid infections, 62 per cent of the respondents in the INDIA TODAY-CVoter MOTN poll express their satisfaction with the Modi government's handling of the pandemic, the same as six months ago. Not only has the government kept infections and deaths low for over a year now, since the last major Omicron wave in January 2022, but there has also been continuous investment in the vaccination programme. Other than Covaxin by Bharat Biotech and Covishield by the Serum Institute of India, Indians can also avail themselves of two other vaccines as booster doses today—Corbevax by Biological E and the nasal vaccine iNCOVACC by Bharat Biotech. Three Indian firms are also developing bivalent vaccines, which will concurrently target more than one Covid sub-variant.

The present comfortable situation along with the hope generated by the ongoing development of more and more indigenous vaccines has significantly reduced the threat of Covid-19. MOTN findings show that 62 per cent feel that Covid is no more a threat but one should remain careful. Around 60 per cent of the respondents also reported no new cases of Covid around them. While there seems no reason for panic or worry in India currently, Covid deaths around the world and past experience with its unpredictable lethality have most still unwilling to accept that the threat is entirely over. Caution is still the best medicine for Covid-19 going into 2023. ■

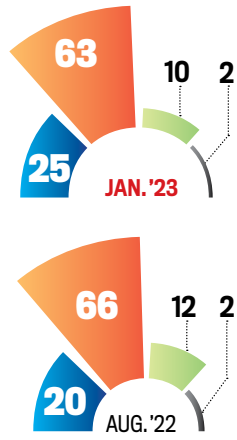


HOW DO YOU RATE THE NARENDRA MODI GOVERNMENT'S HANDLING OF THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC?

Outstanding · Good · Average · Poor · Very poor · DK/ CS

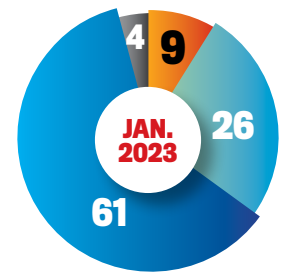
All figures in % and rounded off; DK/ CS: Don't know/ Can't say

Q WHAT DO YOU THINK IS THE CURRENT STATE OF THE PANDEMIC?



It's still a significant threat, the danger hasn't lessened at all · It's not as significant a threat as before but we have to be vigilant · It's not a significant threat any more, life is back to normal · DK/ CS

Q IS THERE A RISE IN COVID CASES IN THE AREA THAT YOU LIVE IN?



Yes, many cases in the past month · Yes, but very few cases · No, new case of Covid around me · DK/ CS